

The Active Bride — A Discussion Guide

*I want us to really focus on all the implications of **Ephesians 5:22–25**. The summary is simple: the wife is to the husband as the church is to Christ. We love to focus on one side of that — the husband leads, the wife follows. But there is so much more in the church → Christ relationship that I believe strongly applies here. Christ empowered the church with the Holy Spirit. Christ gave His life for the church so that the church could be freed from the bondage of its past. And He gave the church agency to "bind and loose" — to forbid and permit actions, to interpret, even to write, our own laws. Viewing the husband-wife relationship in these modes is changing the way I think about my role. How can I empower DeLisa to go into the world and make disciples?*

That is the question this guide is built around — and it cuts both ways across the room. We will spend most of this morning on one thing: **what the church actually does in relation to Christ** — because whatever the church does, the wife does. But we will keep asking the matching question right beside it: **what did Christ give so the church could do it** — because whatever Christ gives, the husband gives. Husbands and wives both have homework here. The wives will keep recognizing themselves in the active bride. The husbands will keep getting asked a harder question than *how do I lead?* — namely, *how do I empower?* Read every verse aloud. Sit with the questions before reaching for the answers. Both sides of the room are in this together.

Audio Overviews

- ☐ Why the Biblical Bride Leads (Deep Dive, 19 min)
- ☐ Biblical Headship and the Active Bride (Debate, 21 min)

Part 1 — The Conventional Reading

For most of church history, Ephesians 5 has been read in one direction. Christ leads → so the husband leads. The church follows → so the wife follows. Lay out the standard reading first, in its strongest form, so we know what we are testing.

The text everyone starts from

Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ. Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife even as Christ is the head of the church, his body, and is himself its Savior. Now as the church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything. Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her... (**Ephesians 5:21–25**, ESV)

Wives, submit to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord. Husbands, love your wives, and do not be harsh with them. (**Colossians 3:18–19**, ESV)

Likewise, wives, be subject to your own husbands, so that even if some do not obey the word, they may be won without a word by the conduct of their wives... (**1 Peter 3:1**, ESV)

Discussion:

1. Three independent letters, three submission commands. Whatever Paul and Peter mean, they mean it more than once. State the conventional reading as strongly as you can: *what is the wife's role in this picture, and what does she do all day?*
2. The conventional reading imagines the wife as a passive recipient — she trusts, defers, submits. Notice the verb the Christ-side gets: *Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her*. What verb does the church-side get in Ephesians 5:24? Is that the *only* thing the church does — and is "gave Himself up" the *only* thing Christ does?
3. Two questions we'll carry through the morning, one per side of the room. **Wives:** whatever the church does in relation to Christ is what you do — so what does the church actually do? **Husbands:** whatever Christ gives the church is what you give — so what did Christ actually give? We've been handed one word each (she *submits*; he *leads*); we're about to find how small those two words have been.

Part 2 — What Did Jesus Tell the Church to Do — and What Did He Give Them?

Before the church does anything, Jesus speaks. Look at what He tells them, what He doesn't, and what He hands them on the way out.

The last commission

All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age. (**Matthew 28:18–20**, ESV)

But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth. (**Acts 1:8**, ESV)

The ascension

And when he had said these things, as they were looking on, he was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight. (**Acts 1:9**, ESV)

Context: Acts 1:9 is the last time Jesus speaks to the disciples in person before the rest of the New Testament unfolds. After this the church has the Spirit (Acts 2), the deposited teaching, and a commission — but not Jesus standing beside them telling them what to do each morning. And He does not send them empty-handed: "*you will receive power*" comes before "*you will be my witnesses*." He empowers, then commissions, then steps back.

Discussion:

4. Jesus gives the commission once, then ascends. He does not stay. He does not phone in. He does not micromanage. Is the church more like an employee waiting for instructions, or an heir given an estate to manage? **Wives:** which of those describes your role at home — and which would you *want* to?

5. Christ pairs the commission with power: "*you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you*." He empowers before He sends. **Husbands:** when you hand your wife a task, a trust, or a corner of the household, do you also hand her the power and resources to carry it — or just the instruction? What is the difference between *delegating* and *empowering*?

6. **Both sides:** name a time you were given a responsibility without being given the authority or resources to fulfill it. How did that feel? Now name a time someone empowered you for something — equipped you, backed you, then got out of the way. Which one produces disciples?

Part 3 — The Church Decides

Watch what happens in Acts 15 — the first major doctrinal crisis the early church faces. Jesus had not explicitly settled the question. Read what they do.

Context

A controversy erupts. Gentile converts are pouring into the church. Some Jewish believers insist they must be circumcised and keep the Law of Moses to be saved (Acts 15:1). The apostles, elders, and the whole church at Jerusalem gather to decide.

The Council

The apostles and the elders were gathered together to consider this matter. And after there had been much debate, Peter stood up... (**Acts 15:6-7**, ESV)

And all the assembly fell silent, and they listened to Barnabas and Paul as they related what signs and wonders God had done through them among the Gentiles. (**Acts 15:12**, ESV)

Then it seemed good to the apostles and the elders, with the whole church, to choose men from among them and send them to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas... (**Acts 15:22**, ESV)

For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay on you no greater burden than these requirements... (**Acts 15:28**, ESV)

Discussion:

7. Read Acts 15:28 again, very carefully: "*it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us*." Is the church reporting an order from heaven, or naming itself as a co-decider with the Spirit? Notice *what made that possible* — the Spirit Christ had given them (Part 2) is the One they are deciding *with*.

8. **Husbands:** the church could co-decide because Christ empowered it to and trusted it to. Do you empower your wife's discernment — invite it, weight it, decide *with* her — or do you require that she defer to yours? Which of those is the Acts 15 pattern?

9. **Wives:** in the real decisions of your household, are you a co-decider "with the Spirit and with him," or a recipient of verdicts already reached? **Both:** what would actually change this week if your household decisions looked like Acts 15 — debate, listening, shared discernment — instead of top-down delivery?

Part 4 — The Church Plants Itself

If Jesus directed every move, we would expect the missionary expansion of the church to follow a top-down pattern. Instead, watch what actually happens.

The Antioch church is planted by anonymous refugees

Now those who were scattered because of the persecution that arose over Stephen traveled as far as Phoenicia and Cyprus and Antioch, speaking the word to no one except Jews. But there were some of them, men of Cyprus and Cyrene, who on coming to Antioch spoke to the Hellenists also, preaching the Lord Jesus. And the hand of the Lord was with them, and a great number who believed turned to the Lord. (**Acts 11:19-21**, ESV)

Context: No apostle plants Antioch. No prophet receives a vision. Anonymous believers, fleeing for their lives after Stephen's martyrdom, start preaching — including, on their own initiative, to non-Jews. The first major Gentile-inclusive church in history is planted by people whose names we will never know.

Antioch becomes the sending base

Now there were in the church at Antioch prophets and teachers, Barnabas, Simeon who was called Niger, Lucius of Cyrene, Manaen a lifelong friend of Herod the tetrarch, and Saul. While they were worshipping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them." Then after fasting and praying they laid their hands on them and sent them off. (**Acts 13:1-3**, ESV)

Discussion:

10. Antioch is planted with *no apostolic supervision*, by anonymous refugees, on their own initiative. Does that fit the "church just receives orders" reading? **Wives:** where in your life have you taken Kingdom initiative without waiting for a green light — and was that faithfulness or overstep?

11. Acts 13: the Spirit speaks, the church discerns, the church *sends*. The whole motion is empowerment flowing outward — set apart, commissioned, released. **Husbands:** Christ's pattern is to send and resource, not to contain. Where could you be *sending and backing* your wife into a calling, rather than keeping her close to home base?

12. **Both:** is there a "set apart for the work to which I have called them" sense on your spouse — or on you — that the household has been quietly sitting on? What would it take to lay hands on it and send it?

Part 5 — "Greater Works Than These"

Quote a verse most readers have never sat with.

Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever believes in me will also do the works that I do; and **greater works than these will he do, because I am going to the Father.** (**John 14:12**, ESV)

Discussion:

13. Jesus says His disciples will do *greater* works than His own — and notice the reason: "*because I am going to the Father.*" His stepping back is precisely what unleashes the greater works. Is this the language of a passive recipient? What does it do to the picture of the church as quiet follower?

14. **Husbands:** is it possible your wife's "greater works" are waiting on your willingness to step back and make room — the way Christ made room by going to the Father? Where might your presence be filling a space she is meant to fill? **Wives:** what work have you shrunk to fit the space someone left you?

Part 6 — The Keys

Jesus delegates real, binding authority to His church. This is not symbolic. Read carefully.

And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and **whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.** (**Matthew 16:18-19**, ESV)

Truly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven. (**Matthew 18:18**, ESV — given to the whole church a chapter later)

It is actually reported that there is sexual immorality among you... Let him who has done this be removed from among you... When you are assembled in the name of the Lord Jesus and my spirit is present, with the power of our Lord Jesus, **you are to deliver this man to Satan...** (**1 Corinthians 5:1-5**, ESV, abridged)

Context: "Bind and loose" was rabbinic legal language — the authority to *forbid* (bind) and *permit* (loose), to interpret the law and render binding rulings. Jesus hands this authority to His church, and the church *used* it: it interpreted the Law afresh (Acts 15 *loosed* the Gentiles from circumcision), it rendered binding decisions, and it even *wrote* — the apostles composed the documents we now call the New Testament, the church's own Spirit-breathed Scripture. 1 Corinthians 5 shows the enforcement side: Paul does not himself excommunicate the offender; he commands the Corinthian church to do it. The church interprets, decides, writes, and enforces.

Discussion:

15. Jesus *gives* the keys — He does not keep them. The church binds and looses, forbids and permits, interprets the law, renders rulings, and even writes new Scripture. This is delegation on a staggering scale. Does that sound like an institution that waits for orders, or one entrusted with real legislative authority?

16. **Husbands:** what real authority have you actually *handed over* to your wife — not delegated-but-supervised, but genuinely released, the way Christ released the keys? Where do you take the keys back the moment a decision worries you? **Wives:** where do you already hold keys in your home, and where have they been quietly reclaimed?

17. **Both:** Paul *rebukes* the Corinthian church for *failing* to use the authority it was given (1 Cor 5:2). Is it possible to sin by *under-using* delegated authority — to leave keys unturned out of false deference? Where might that be happening in your marriage, in either direction?

Part 7 — Mary's "Yes" — and How She Was Empowered

If anyone in Scripture is the icon of submission, it is Mary. Read her actual words — and notice how God prepares her for the role.

The Annunciation

And the angel answered her, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy — the Son of God..." (**Luke 1:35**, ESV)
And Mary said, "Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word." And the angel departed from her. (**Luke 1:38**, ESV)

Context: Notice what comes *between* the angel's announcement (v. 35) and Mary's yes (v. 38). It is not just silence and assent. She has already asked, in verse 34, "How will this be, since I am a virgin?" She interrogates the angel before consenting. And notice *how* she is equipped for the vocation: "the Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you" — the same Spirit-empowerment language used of the church at Pentecost (Acts 1:8).

The Magnificat

And Mary said, "My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior, for he has looked on the humble estate of his servant. For behold, from now on all generations will call me blessed; for he who is mighty has done great things for me, and holy is his name. And his mercy is for those who fear him from generation to generation. **He has shown strength with his arm; he has scattered the proud in the thoughts of their hearts; he has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate; he has filled the hungry with good things, and the rich he has sent away empty.** He has helped his servant Israel, in remembrance of his mercy, as he spoke to our fathers, to Abraham and to his offspring forever." (**Luke 1:46–55**, ESV)

Discussion:

18. Mary's yes in verse 38 is read as the perfect submissive answer. But she *asks the question first* (v. 34) and *sings a revolutionary song after* (vv. 46–55). Is she an information-free recipient, or an agent who consents after understanding and then prophesies?

19. Mary is empowered for her vocation exactly the way the church is — "*the Holy Spirit will come upon you, the power of the Most High will overshadow you.*" God empowers before He sends, every time. **Both sides:** where have you tried to *send* (or to *go*) without first being empowered — taking on a calling in your own strength? What would receiving the power first have changed?

20. **Husbands:** the Magnificat is the voice of a woman who sees thrones cast down and the proud scattered. If your wife has a voice like that, does your marriage make room for it — or quiet it? **Wives:** where has your "Magnificat" gone unsung?

Part 8 — Priscilla, Phoebe, Junia, Lydia, Nympha, Chloe

These names recur in the New Testament. Look at what each woman is doing — and at how the men around her respond.

Priscilla teaches Apollos

Now a Jew named Apollos, a native of Alexandria, came to Ephesus. He was an eloquent man, competent in the Scriptures... When Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took him aside and explained to him the way of God more accurately. (**Acts 18:24–26**, ESV)

Context: Apollos is a respected preacher. Priscilla — a married woman, traveling with her husband Aquila — takes him aside privately and *corrects his doctrine*. Notably, "Priscilla and Aquila" is the order four out of six times their names appear together in the NT — the wife's name listed first, which was unusual. Aquila is right there beside her, co-laboring, not silencing her.

Phoebe

I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant [Greek: *diakonos*] of the church at Cenchreae, that you may welcome her in the Lord in a way worthy of the saints, and help her in whatever she may need from you, for she has been a patron [Greek: *prostatis*] of many and of myself as well. (**Romans 16:1–2**, ESV)

Context: *Diakonos* is the same word used in 1 Timothy 3:8 for the deacon office. *Prostatis* means patron, benefactor, protector — a person of independent social standing and resources. Phoebe is also the courier of Romans, which means she is the first person in history to read aloud, and likely *explain*, the Letter to the Romans to a congregation. Notice Paul's instruction: "*help her in whatever she may need*" — he resources and backs her.

Junia

Greet Andronicus and Junia, my kinsmen and my fellow prisoners. **They are well known to the apostles**, and they were in Christ before me. (**Romans 16:7**, ESV)

Context: Junia is a female name. The early church read her as a woman for the first thousand years. Some translations read "well known *among* the apostles" — i.e., Junia *is* an apostle. Either reading places her in apostolic company.

Lydia hosts the Philippian church

One who heard us was a woman named Lydia, from the city of Thyatira, a seller of purple goods, who was a worshiper of God. The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul. And after she was baptized, and her household as well, she urged us, saying, "If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come to my house and stay." And she prevailed upon us. (**Acts 16:14–15**, ESV)

Context: Lydia is wealthy in her own right (purple cloth was a luxury good). She decides for her whole household. She hosts the Philippian church — the church she effectively founds. Notice the verb in the last line: *she prevailed upon us*. She does not defer to Paul. She presses him.

Nympha and Chloe

Give my greetings to the brothers at Laodicea, and to Nympha and the church in her house. (**Colossians 4:15**, ESV)

For it has been reported to me by Chloe's people that there is quarreling among you, my brothers. (**1 Corinthians 1:11**, ESV)

Context: Nympha hosts a church. Chloe has "people" (a household, employees, agents) and reports to Paul about a fellow congregation. Both are women with standing, resources, and active ministry.

Discussion:

21. Five named women, five kinds of ministry: doctrinal correction, diaconal service and patronage, apostolic-adjacent work, church-founding hospitality, inter-congregational reporting. Are these *exceptions* to a passive-recipient rule, or the actual texture of the apostolic-era church?

22. Look at the men. Aquila co-labors with Priscilla (and lets her name go first). Paul *commends* Phoebe and tells a whole church to *resource* her. The apostles *recognize* Junia. The men empower rather than restrain. **Husbands:** are you a Paul-commending-Phoebe and an Aquila-beside-Priscilla — or are you the obstacle these women happened not to have? Name the difference concretely.

23. **Wives:** which of these five women do you most identify with — and what, honestly, is keeping you from operating like her? Is the obstacle scriptural, or is it cultural, fear, or a lack of backing?

Part 9 — The *Eshet Chayil* — The Active Bride Already in Wisdom Literature

The pattern we are tracing in the NT is not a NT innovation. Read Proverbs 31 — the climactic poem of the entire book of Proverbs.

An excellent wife who can find? She is far more precious than jewels. The heart of her husband trusts in her, and he will have no lack of gain. She does him good, and not harm, all the days of her life. She seeks wool and flax, and works with willing hands. She is like the ships of the merchant; she brings her food from afar. She rises while it is yet night and provides food for her household and portions for her maidens. **She considers a field and buys it; with the fruit of her hands she plants a vineyard.** She dresses herself with strength and makes her arms strong. **She perceives that her merchandise is profitable.** Her lamp does not go out at night... Her husband is known in the gates when he sits among the elders of the land. **She makes linen garments and sells them; she delivers sashes to the merchant.** Strength and dignity are her clothing, and she laughs at the time to come. **She opens her mouth with wisdom, and the teaching of kindness is on her tongue.** She looks well to the ways of her household and does not eat the bread of idleness. Her children rise up and call her blessed; her husband also, and he praises her... (**Proverbs 31:10–28**, ESV, abridged)

Context: *Eshet chayil* — usually translated "an excellent wife" or "a wife of noble character" — literally means *a woman of valor* or *a woman of strength*. *Chayil* is the same word used of David's mighty men. This is not a domestic compliment; it is a heroic title.

Discussion:

24. List everything this woman does on her own initiative: buys real estate, evaluates business profitability, runs a textile operation, sells goods, gives to the poor, teaches with wisdom, manages a household economy with employees. Where in the passage does the text say she clears these decisions with her husband?

25. The empowerment is named right at the start: "*the heart of her husband trusts in her*" (v. 11). That trust is the green light for everything that follows. **Husbands:** does your wife experience your *trust* as a release, or your *oversight* as a leash? Which one would let her "consider a field and buy it"? **Wives:** what would you build, start, or attempt if you knew you were fully trusted and fully backed?

26. Verse 23: while she runs all this, the husband "is known in the gates" — doing his own work, not supervising hers. **Both:** is that a picture of a disengaged husband, or of a head secure enough not to micromanage? What is the difference between the two in practice?

Part 10 — Deborah, Esther, Huldah

Three Old Testament women who exercise massive public authority. Read what they do.

Deborah

Now Deborah, a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth, was judging Israel at that time. She used to sit under the palm of Deborah between Ramah and Bethel in the hill country of Ephraim, and the people of Israel came up to her for judgment. (**Judges 4:4–5**, ESV)

She sent and summoned Barak the son of Abinoam from Kedesh-naphtali and said to him, "Has not the LORD, the God of Israel, commanded you, 'Go, gather your men at Mount Tabor...'" (**Judges 4:6**, ESV)

Context: Deborah is the *judge* — the political and spiritual authority over all Israel. She summons the male general Barak and commands him in YHWH's name. Her husband Lappidoth is named once (4:4) and never appears again — a marital identifier, not an authorizer.

Esther

Then Esther told them to reply to Mordecai, "Go, gather all the Jews to be found in Susa, and hold a fast on my behalf, and do not eat or drink for three days, night or day. I and my young women will also fast as you do. Then I will go to the king, though it is against the law, and **if I perish, I perish.**" (**Esther 4:15–16**, ESV)

Context: Esther independently decides to risk her life — without consulting her husband (the king, the very one she must risk approaching). She instructs Mordecai to gather the Jews and fast. She is the agent here; the men around her receive *her* directives.

Huldah

So Hilkiah the priest, and Ahikam, and Achbor, and Shaphan, and Asaiah went to **Huldah the prophetess**, the wife of Shallum... and they talked with her. And she said to them, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel: 'Tell the man who sent you to me, Thus says the LORD, Behold, I will bring disaster upon this place and upon its inhabitants, all the words of the book that the king of Judah has read. Because they have forsaken me and have made offerings to other gods, that they might provoke me to anger with all the work of their hands, therefore my wrath will be kindled against this place, and it will not be quenched. But to the king of Judah, who sent you to inquire of the LORD, thus shall you say to him, Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel: Regarding the words that you have heard, because your heart was penitent, and you humbled yourself before the LORD, when you heard how I spoke against this place and against its inhabitants, that they should become a desolation and a curse, and you have torn your clothes and wept before me, I also have heard you, declares the LORD. Therefore, behold, I will gather you to your fathers, and you shall be gathered to your grave in peace, and your eyes shall not see all the disaster that I will bring upon this place.'" (**2 Kings 22:14–20**, ESV)

Context: A scroll has been found in the temple; King Josiah needs to know if it is genuine Scripture. The high priest, royal officials, and the king's scribe — the most powerful men in Judah — go to *Huldah*, and she delivers a two-part oracle: national judgment for idolatry (vv. 16–17), then mercy to the penitent king (vv. 18–20). Hers is the definitive verdict — it validates the scroll and grounds Josiah's sweeping reform. Note who is *not* consulted: Jeremiah and Zephaniah were prophesying in Jerusalem at this very time, yet the king's men came to *her*. Her husband Shallum is only a marital identifier.

Discussion:

27. Deborah judges *Israel*. Esther saves the entire Jewish people. Huldah validates *Scripture itself* for a king. Are these "exceptions"? Or part of the pattern? In all three, the woman's husband is mentioned briefly, then disappears. What is the text doing by not making the husband the gatekeeper?

28. Each of these women was empowered by God and *unhindered* by her husband. **Husbands:** have you ever needed to be Lappidoth — to step back so that the gift on your wife could operate at full scale? Is a husband who doesn't get in the way a failure, or a picture of a secure head? **Wives:** where has "biblical womanhood" been used to keep you decision-light, when Scripture's own examples run the other way?

Part 11 — The Last Voice in the Canon

Read the final invitation of the Bible.

The Spirit and the Bride say, "Come." And let the one who hears say, "Come." And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price. (**Revelation 22:17**, ESV)

Context: This is the canonical climax. The last named voice in Scripture before Jesus's final words is *the Spirit and the Bride together*. They speak as one. The Bride is not silent at the end of the story.

Discussion:

29. The eschatological Bride *speaks* — and she speaks *with the Spirit she was given*. The whole arc lands here: empowered by the Spirit (Part 2, Part 7), the Bride now joins the Spirit in the final invitation. Is the Bride's destiny silence, or speech?

30. **Both sides:** if the Bride's eternal role is to speak alongside the Spirit, is the wife's present-tense calling to *practice silence now* or to *practice speech now*, to be perfected later? And **husbands** — does your marriage rehearse the Revelation 22 duet, or does it mute one of the two voices?

Part 12 — What the Husband Gives: The Thread Pulled Whole

All morning we have watched two things at once — the Bride acting, and Christ empowering her to act. Now pull that second thread out. The sentence that commands the wife's submission keeps going, and what it says the husband (Christ) *does* is the part the conventional reading races past.

Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word, so that he might present the church to himself in splendor, without spot or wrinkle or any such thing, that she might be holy and without blemish. In the same way husbands should love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as Christ does the church... (**Ephesians 5:25–29**, ESV)

Context: Notice the *purpose clauses* — "that he might sanctify her," "present her in splendor," "that she might be holy." Christ's self-giving is aimed not at her compliance but at her *glory*; in Paul's grammar the whole point of the husband's sacrifice is the wife's flourishing. Three gifts have surfaced all morning; here they are whole.

A. Christ empowered the church with the Holy Spirit (Parts 2, 4, 7)

And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth... (**John 14:16-17**, ESV)

When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth... (**John 16:13**, ESV)

Christ equipped the church before sending it — His own Spirit, power, gifts, guidance. The church's agency is granted and resourced by its head, not self-generated.

B. Christ freed the church from the bondage of its past

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed. (**Luke 4:18**, ESV)

We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to nothing, so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin. (**Romans 6:6**, ESV)

For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery. (**Galatians 5:1**, ESV)

Christ's self-giving (Eph 5:25) frees the church *from* its bondage — sin, shame, the law's condemnation, the past — and *for* its mission and glory.

C. Christ delegated authority — to interpret, bind and loose, even to write (Part 6)

I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven... (**Matthew 16:19**, ESV)

For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us... (**Acts 15:28**, ESV)

Christ gave the church the Spirit and the authority to interpret, render binding decisions, and even *write* the Scriptures we now obey — co-author of its own law, not merely an enforcer of pre-written statutes.

Discussion:

31. Three gifts: **the Spirit** (empowerment), **the cross** (liberation), **the keys** (delegated authority). **Husbands**, one at a time: (a) how do you *empower* your wife — pour capacity into her? (b) how does your self-giving *free* her from what binds her — old wounds, shame, fear? (c) what authority have you actually *delegated*? Be specific on all three.

32. **Wives**: name what you most need from your husband under each heading — to be empowered, to be freed, to be entrusted. Which of the three is most missing right now? **Husbands**: listen to the answer without defending.

33. Ephesians 5:27 says the husband's whole aim is to present his wife "in splendor... holy and without blemish." **Both**: is the marriage you are building aimed at her *splendor* or merely at her *compliance*? What's the visible difference between a husband working toward his wife's glory and one working toward his own comfort?

The question the conventional reading never asks the husband

The conventional reading asks the husband one question: *how do I lead her?* The icon, read fully, asks a different one. Christ's headship is a headship of *empowerment* — He gives the Spirit, frees from bondage, delegates real authority, all so the church can "go into all the world and make disciples." If the husband is the Christ-figure, his question is not *how do I keep her in line* but:

How do I empower my wife to go into the world and make disciples?

And here is *why* that's the right question, not a concession. The Kingdom is not a machine to run but a web of relationships to enter — eternal life *is* knowing God (John 17:3), and the whole Law hangs on two relational commands (Matt 22:37-40). If the Kingdom advances by relationship, and women are — broadly — the relational specialists, the most strategic thing a man can do is release his wife into her element: putting his household's strongest player on the field, not the bench.

34. Sit with that personally — and **both** of you answer it. **Husbands**: name three concrete things you could do this month to empower your wife the way Christ empowered the church: to equip her, free her, back her, and send her. **Wives**: name three things that would actually help you go — and tell him.

Part 13 — Synthesis: Reading the Icon in Both Directions

Now let us return to Ephesians 5 with everything we have read.

...as the church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything.

Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her... (**Ephesians 5:24-25**, ESV)

Discussion:

35. The icon has two sides. Husband : wife :: Christ : church. The conventional reading runs it one way: *Christ leads → the husband leads*. Run it both ways: *the church does X → the wife does X; Christ gives Y → the husband gives Y*. From everything this morning, fill in both X and Y.

36. We spent twelve passages watching the church *decide doctrine, plant itself, sing revolutionary songs, hold keys, teach, host, govern, send, judge nations, save peoples, validate Scripture, and speak the canon's final invitation* — all of it *empowered, freed, and authorized* by Christ. Is "*she submits, he leads*" adequate for either side?

37. The icon's *asymmetry* is real — the husband dies for the wife, not she for him; Christ initiates, the church responds. But asymmetry is not passivity, and headship is not control. **Both sides:** state the difference in your own words.

Where this leaves us

Reading the icon in both directions does not dissolve the asymmetry — it specifies what the asymmetry actually contains:

- **Husband as Christ-figure:** initiator, the one who dies — *and the one who empowers, frees, authorizes, and sends*. Headship is not control but empowerment: he gives her every resource (as Christ gave the Spirit), frees her from her past (as Christ freed the church), delegates real authority (the keys), and sends her out — aiming, in everything, at her splendor.
- **Wife as church-figure:** agent and executor, who builds while He is away, holds the keys, and speaks the final invitation. Empowered, freed, and authorized — she goes into the world and makes disciples.

The husband leads not by daily command but by cruciform self-giving that *empowers*. The wife follows not by silent compliance but by Spirit-empowered, mission-driven execution of a shared Kingdom direction — and by the *ezer kenegdo* work of speaking against him when he drifts.

The deepest question the icon poses to the husband is not "how do I lead her?" but "**how do I empower her to go into the world and make disciples?**" — because that is precisely what Christ did for His bride. **The wife is the Active Bride. The icon requires it — and the husband's job is to empower it.**

Part 14 — Bringing It Home

Closing questions for personal reflection and group discussion — for both sides of the room.

38. Think of a marriage you respect. How much of the wife's contribution looks like *passive submission*, and how much looks like *agentive execution she has been empowered for*? What words would you actually use to describe what she does?

39. The conventional reading silences the *ezer kenegdo* function — the wife's calling to expose her husband's drift from the Kingdom; the active-bride reading restores it. **Husbands:** when your wife questions your direction, do you receive it as a gift or resent it? **Wives:** do you speak, or stay quiet to keep the peace? What did Jesus think of those who never questioned anything?

40. **Husbands:** finish this sentence out loud — "*This week, one concrete way I will empower my wife to go and make disciples is _____.*" **Wives:** finish this one — "*One place I sense God sending me, that I have been waiting for permission to go, is _____.*" Trade answers.

41. If you taught this to a newly engaged couple, what would they need to hear *first* — "Wife, you are an agent" or "Husband, your headship is empowerment, not command"? Which side of the icon does the modern church more often distort, and why?

42. **The relational Kingdom.** Is it true, in your experience, that women tend to carry the relational work — in families, friendships, churches? If the Kingdom is fundamentally *relational*, what follows for how a husband should spend his influence? **Husbands:** where might you be playing a relational position your wife plays better — and what would handing it to her look like?

43. **Submission, redefined — test this definition:** *a wife submits by believing her husband when he tells her she is beautiful, powerful, capable, and authorized to lead people to the Kingdom of God — and then acting on it.* **Wives:** is it harder to obey a command or to believe a commendation? Which does your husband actually ask of you? **Husbands:** what do your words over your wife tell her she is — and is it true? (Compare Eph 5:27: Christ presents the church *in splendor*; the church submits by believing what He says it is — and going.)

Suggested Further Reading

The church as Spirit-empowered agent: Esau McCauley, *Reading While Black*; Lesslie Newbigin, *The Open Secret* and *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*; Michael Gorman, *Becoming the Gospel*; N.T. Wright, *Surprised by Hope*. **Women's agency and the ezer recovery:* Sarah Coakley, *God, Sexuality, and the Self* (Mary's agentive yes); Carolyn Custis James, *Half the Church* and *Malestrom*. **Full treatment:** the companion handout *Women in Family and Ministry: The Differences That Remain*, §III.

The discussion-form companion to §III of "Women in Family and Ministry." Work through it aloud, everyone holding a Bible, husbands and wives both answering — not toward a predetermined conclusion but to discover what the text says: about the church and therefore the wife, about Christ and therefore the husband.*